

As big conglomerates become bigger, the small consumer must use diverse art forms for activism and turn **MEDIA PRODUCER**

I want to suggest that the 20th century definitions of public and private are redundant today. The implications are far-reaching: the public/private distinction was the primary lens through which culture was seen in modernity. In India, this model became impossible to sustain after liberalisation in the 1980s. The regime was prepared for more economic freedom—not anticipating that the post-Independence model of cultural control originating in the 1950s would be fundamentally damaged.

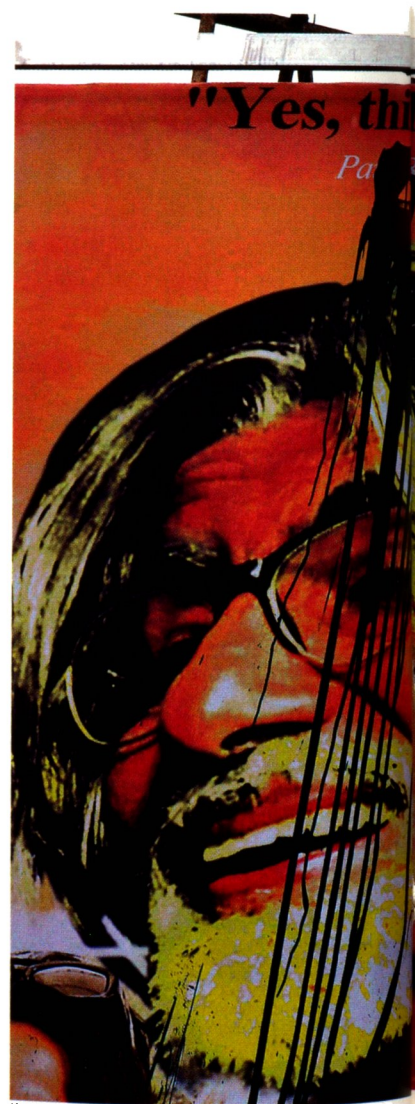
The 1950s model was based on a centralised regime managed by the post-colonial elite. In the social theory of this model, the public was simply the state and the private was most forms of life outside the state. The conflation of the public with the state was a 20th century European phenomenon. By contrast, 19th century radicals and utopians had dreamed of a public realm autonomous of the state and large industry, a critical resource for free citizens. In India, the state/public was the guarantor of the cultural code of the nation as a whole—all legitimate creative forms had to pass the test of 'Indian-ness'. Less authentic cultural practices like popular cinema were subject to regulation and censorship. The 1950s also put in place a vast bureaucratic regime for culture, staffed by regime-appointed individuals across arts institutions—a model that has survived.

Indira Gandhi took this model and transformed it, during the 1970s, into a paranoid structure of control. The cosmopolitan trace of the Nehru era was purged, a new official xenophobia was added to the model. The foreign connection became the marker of an internal fifth column, the ultimate betrayal of national culture and sovereignty. The control structure was appropriately modified to include this new dispensation. International

Silent state: Raj Thackeray supporters defaced a poster of Amitabh Bachchan-starrer, *The Last Lear*

The Singur Effect

ACTIVISTS OF ALL TYPES, WHO SEE THEMSELVES IGNORED IN THE FAST-MOVING BIG MEDIA INTERFACE, NOW CONSTITUTE THEMSELVES AS THE MEDIA. IT COULD BE A GOAN ACTIVIST SPARKING A GLOBAL PROTEST AGAINST DESTRUCTIVE MINING OR MAMATA BANERJEE ORCHESTRATING A SOCIAL AND MEDIA EVENT, PARALYSING THE STATE.



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